StoryCast: Research and Design Document
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1. Project Overview

StoryCast is a three-page accessible microsite built around aviation storytelling. The platform lets visitors listen to audio documentaries, watch video stories, and read full transcripts all without needing an account, app, or plugin.

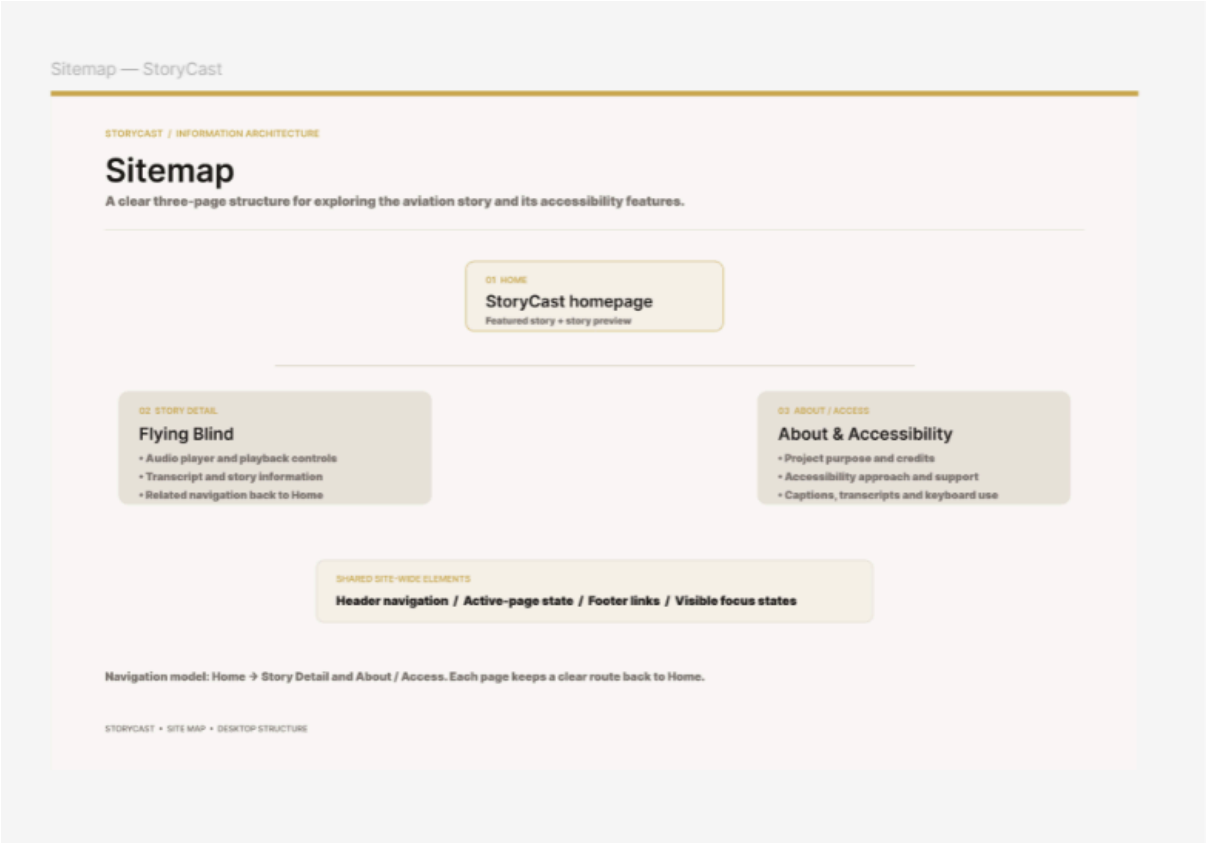
The site was built with semantic HTML5, Sass, CSS Grid, Flexbox, and vanilla JavaScript only. No frameworks were used. The goal was to build something that works for every user including those using screen readers, keyboard-only navigation, or low-bandwidth connections.

Three stories were chosen to represent different angles of aviation: Flying Blind (a first-person survival account), Kigali to the World (a documentary about RwandAir's growth), and The Last Approach (a historical account of aviation safety reforms).

2. Information Architecture

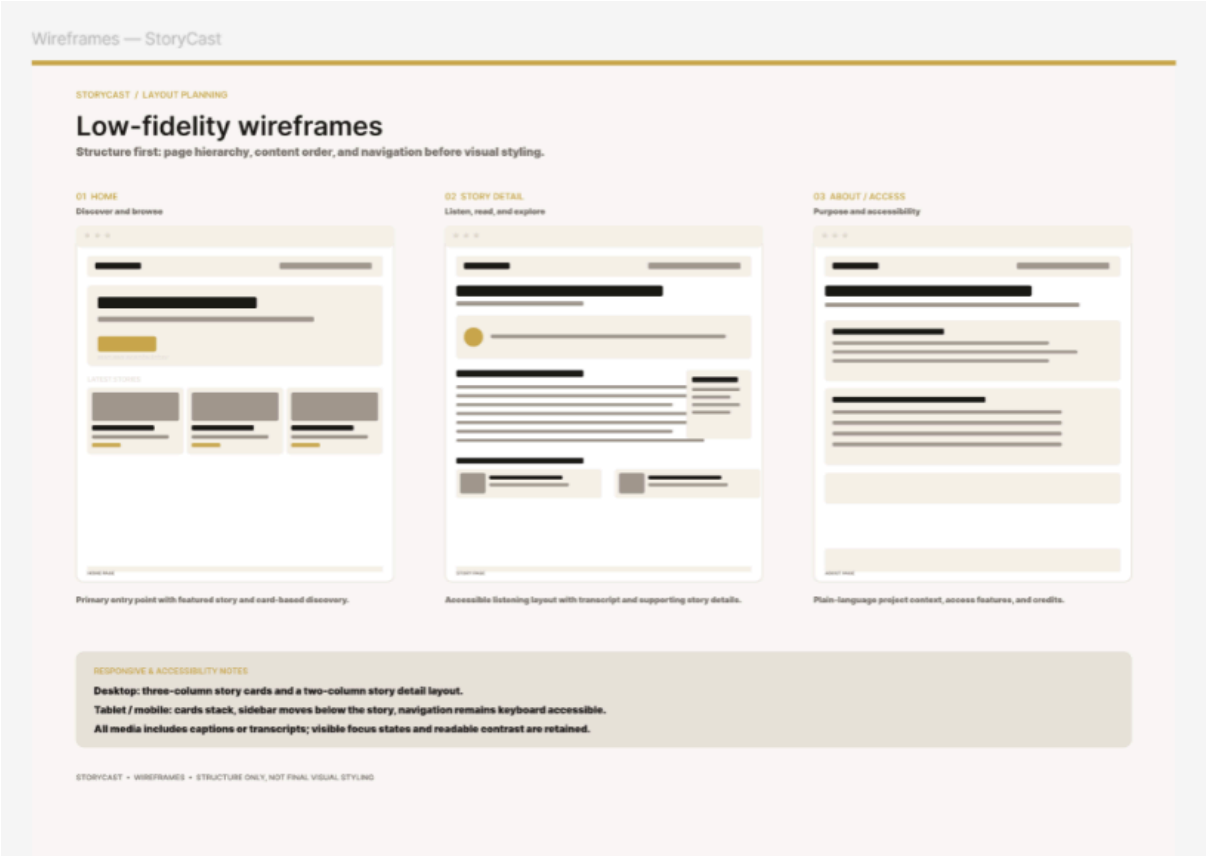
The site uses a flat three-page hierarchy. No story is more than one click from the homepage.

- Home (index.html) → links to all three story pages and the About page via the navigation
- Story pages (story/flying-blind.html, story/the-last-approach.html, story/kigali-to-the-world.html) → each links back to Home and shows two related story cards at the bottom
- About (about.html) → reachable from every page via the navigation bar



3. Wireframes and High-Fidelity Mockups

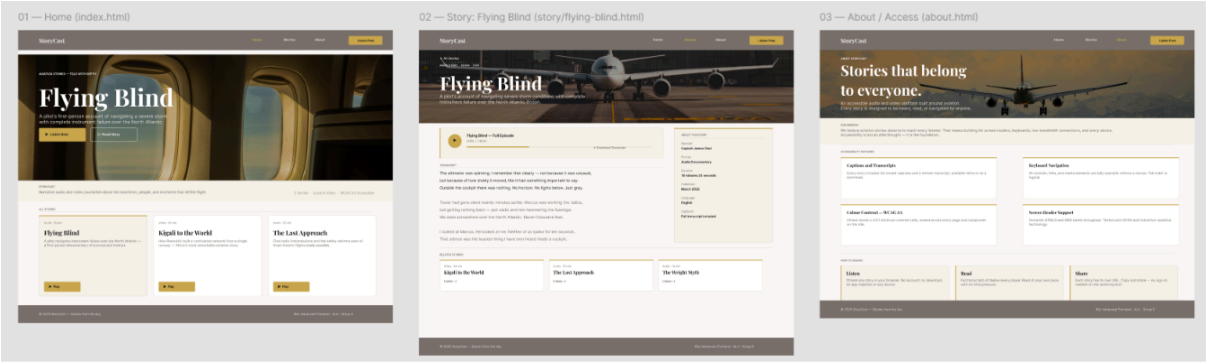
All three pages were designed in Figma before any code was written.



Home page: Full-width hero with the featured story, a three-column story card grid below. On mobile the grid collapses to a single column.

Story page: Two-column layout with the audio or video player and transcript on the left, and a metadata sidebar on the right. On tablet and below the sidebar drops underneath the transcript.

About page: Hero section followed by a mission statement, a two-by-two grid of accessibility feature cards, and a three-column engagement section. All grids collapse to one column on mobile.



Figma file:
https://www.figma.com/design/jWX9RRweP7Rc9vNMAJiFT8/StoryCast-%E2%80%94-Aviation-Microsite-Mockups

4. Accessibility Approach

Transcripts and captions
Every audio and video story has a WebVTT caption file loaded via the HTML <track> element. A full written transcript is printed on each story page and available as a plain-text download from the assets/transcripts/ folder.

Contrast ratios: WCAG 2.1 AA
All text was tested against its background:

- Cream (#faf8f5) on deep greige (#78716C) = 4.51:1 — passes AA
- Dark (#1c1917) on warm white (#faf8f5) = 15.9:1 — passes AAA
- Dark (#1c1917) on gold (#c9a84c) = 7.35:1 — passes AAA
  Gold is used only as a button background and decorative accent, never as body text.

Keyboard navigation
Every page has a skip link at the top that becomes visible when focused via the Tab key. All links, buttons, and media controls are reachable by keyboard. The mobile hamburger button updates its aria-expanded value when toggled. Visible focus rings are applied globally via :focus-visible.

ARIA attributes

- aria-label on the main nav and audio elements
- aria-current="page" on the active navigation link
- aria-describedby linking the audio player to its figcaption
- aria-expanded on the mobile navigation toggle
- aria-controls linking the toggle to the nav list
- .sr-only utility class hides decorative text from screen readers